

gave programmers an operating system that wasn't paid like Unix, but was compatible with Unix commands, included a text editor, a compiler and an interpreter. More importantly, it came on to the scene before Richard Stallman's GNU (GNU is Not Unix) operating system—the original proposed Saviour.

For so many years, Linux was an operating system for programmers only, after which it expanded its audience to geeks who didn't mind poking and probing the system to figure out even the simplest tasks. Look at Linux today, and the journey's been well worth it—that this writer's 57 year old uncle uses Xubuntu with fewer requests for tech support than for Windows, is testament to how easy Linux has become to use—at least for the basic “I need office-Internet-IM-e-mail” home user.

With distributions like Ubuntu (which you can find on this month's *Freeware* DVD), Linux has finally come into its own. The applications have always been there, but no distribution brought them together as wonderfully as Ubuntu did. The interface is ridiculously easy to use, and even installing it is a breeze—the fact that it's a live CD means that you can actually enjoy a couple of rounds of Solitaire (or any other game, for that matter) while the OS installs in the background!

Even installing applications—formerly a nightmare involving RPMs, dependencies and code compilations—has become a smooth process across all distributions. Just fire up the distribution's *package manager*, search for the software you want (you can even search by description), and mark it for installation. The software will come to you from an online repository—complete with dependencies and application menu entries. It's an enviable selling point for a platform to have, and you can even see Windows users yearning for something like this.

The bottom line is clear: unless you're a gamer, or don't have a mature Linux alternative to the software you're already using, there's no reason for you not to be using Linux. At the very least, give the Ubuntu Live CD a whirl—it won't alter your PC, but you might soon want it to.

Open Is Cool

With the open source movement getting more popular, everybody wants to get some love from enthusiasts. In stark contrast to Gates' letter to hobbyists, you can now visit <http://www.microsoft.com/opensource/> to find out what Microsoft's doing to promote the open source philosophy. In fact, if you're a developer on Microsoft's .net platform, they'll let you study the code of the Common Language Runtime (CLR)—the core component of the platform—to enable you to optimise your applications for better performance. You can't modify the code, though—just study it. It's

not free as Stallman would have it, but it's something.

And it's not just software that benefits from this burgeoning free culture. The philosophy of "if you like it, share it" comes to the aid of budding movie makers and artists as well, thanks to Creative Commons (CC). Release your work under a CC license, and you're giving users the right to share it with their friends if they like it—which is another tenet of the free software movement. Of course, while all CC-licensed work is free of cost, they may not all be free to modify and / or used for commercial purposes—there are many variations. By throwing yourself open to the community in general, you're actually widening your audience—people have nothing to lose by listening to a free album or watching a free movie—you'll get your feedback, and if people like your work, you'll get donations. Recently, Nine Inch Nails opened up to the world by releasing their new album *The Slip* as a free, CC-licensed download. Get it here: <http://theslip.nin.com/>—it's even available in the raw WAV format.

Software, music, movies—what next?

Beyond Bits

It may sound like just another fad caused by online communities, but openness now transcends content—software, music or movies. Even hardware is going open—notably, Sun started the OpenSPARC project to create an “open source processor”. The design of the UltraSPARC processor is freely available to study and modify, and the aim is for everyone to contribute to creating the best design—which Sun will then manufacture (you could too, if you have a fabrication plant lying about). It’ll also help developers build better applications optimised for the processor.

Imagine being able to design a cell phone just the way you want it—get rid of an interface annoyance, change the location of a port, whatever you want. Enter

OpenMoko, the open source cell phone project. Not



The Neo 1973 is the manifestation of OpenMoko's initiative. Right now, it's only for developers, and you can get your hands on the CAD files if you want to change the design



Is this what the open source car will look like? This is one of the many proposed designs—a three-wheeled approach seems to be rather popular online, too

only is the phone's operating system based on Linux, you can redesign the phone any way you want. If you're a developer, you can order yourself a unit of the Neo 1973—the current prototype—and hack away to your heart's content.

Then there's the marketing gimmick that became more popular than the product it was marketing. When a firm called Opencola wanted to promote their collaborative search software, they decided to create an open source cola (yes, as in Coca-) to promote open source. The recipe for the cola is available for study, experimentation and modification, and the popularity of the cola has surpassed the popularity of the software it was supposed to promote. Around the same time, students in Denmark's IT-University in Copenhagen were brewing (literally) an open source beer with the same intentions.

Could it get any weirder? How about an open source car? It's rather self-explanatory—the design for the car is released to the community at large, and anyone who chooses to modify it, can. Any resulting cars, though, will likely not be available free of cost.

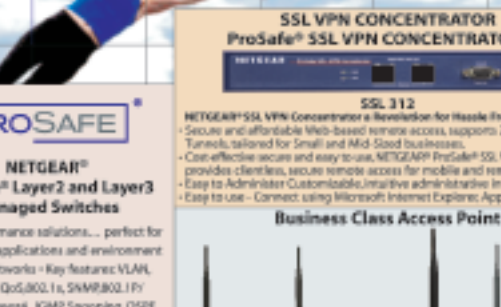
Full Circle

We've gone from sharing software we liked to being called thieves for it to doing it anyway, to being called heroes for it. Soon, it'll stop being such a big deal, and this open, share-what-you-like culture will be taken for granted once again—at least, that's what we hope. It doesn't even matter that only a small percentage of users will actually contribute to further development—just the knowledge that they can is enough. ■

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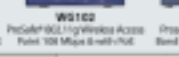
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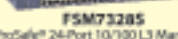


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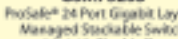
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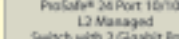


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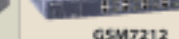


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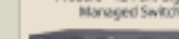


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